



ANNUAL REPORT 2023

INTRODUCTION TO THE FOOD INDUSTRY



EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This annual report offers a comprehensive overview of the "Regenerating Local Food Systems in Kenya" project, generously funded by the DOEN Foundation, Biovision Foundation, Koppert Foundation, and Haella Foundation. The project is committed to implementing sustainable agricultural practices through agroecology and regenerative agriculture, focusing on syntropic food forestry, water management, market linkage, and strategic partnerships.

PROJECT OVERVIEW

The project has achieved significant progress in various areas, including training farmers in regenerative agriculture, improving water management, establishing market linkages, and forming strategic partnerships. The project's impact has extended to monthly training sessions, attracting farmers from diverse regions, and establishing a solid presence in Makueni and Nairobi.



MOST MEANINGFUL CHANGES

Change 1: Training Farmers on Regenerative Agriculture

Over 2023, we significantly increased the number of monthly training sessions to educate farmers in basic syntropic agroforestry techniques. As a result, 508 farmers completed the training and gained valuable knowledge about sustainable agricultural practices. Additionally, we successfully formed 20 farmer groups, fostering collaboration and information sharing among the farming community.

Furthermore, our efforts have yielded promising results in terms of the adoption of regenerative agriculture principles. Notably, 20% of the trained farmers have made a comprehensive transition to regenerative agriculture by establishing syntropic farms. Another 40% of the farmers have incorporated two or three regenerative agriculture principles into their practices, such as cultivating diverse plant species and cover crops, and reducing their reliance on synthetic inputs. This reflects a positive and growing trend towards more sustainable farming methods within the community.

In addition to promoting sustainable farming practices, we have made significant strides in introducing a diverse range of green traditional vegetables to the community. This initiative has challenged initial misconceptions about these vegetables and has been accompanied by educational cooking workshops highlighting the nutritional value of these nutritious greens. Through these efforts, we aim to promote a more diverse and nutritious diet among the community members while supporting local agricultural biodiversity.

We will expand our cooking workshops to include knowledge sharing on vegetable preparation from the Makueni and Nairobi regions.



CHANGE 2 :WATER MANAGEMENT



We have made significant progress by building 13 water pans, each with a capacity of 800,000 liters. This crucial initiative combats water scarcity in semi-arid regions by replenishing groundwater and ensuring access to water during periods of drought.

In addition, we have formed a dedicated water committee to strategize the equitable distribution of water from a borehole drilled by Feedback to the Future (FttF). All these concerted efforts are aimed at establishing a comprehensive community-level water management framework to rejuvenate the hydrological cycle in the area



CHANGE 3: MARKET LINKAGE



As a result of organizing a vendors workshop in Viwandani to address the issue of harmful pesticide use, a shop has been established to distribute locally sourced food products from Makueni. This important development has played a crucial role in promoting access to clean and safe food products while also contributing to the reduction of harmful pesticide use in the region.

Furthermore, we have been actively engaging and encouraging farmers in Makueni to prioritize the production of clean and safe food for their families. This effort also aims to empower them to become prosumers, who are not only consumers but also producers for the food market.



Building on these activities, we advocate for the use and encouragement of organic food production. These efforts are intended to enhance our market linkage activities further and contribute to a more sustainable and healthy food system for the region.

CHANGE 4: PARTNERSHIPS

We are excited to announce that we have forged strong partnerships with the Makueni County Government and Grassroots Economist. In June 2023, we had the honour of hosting the Deputy Governor and her delegation of 14 to shine a spotlight on agroecology, regenerative agriculture and food forestry and contribute to the development of agroecology policies at the county level. Our collaboration with Grassroots Economy, a key strategic partner, is geared towards empowering farmers to work together and harness underutilized resources

These partnerships are pivotal in our efforts to champion sustainable farming practices in the future. Additionally, we have proactively initiated discussions and collaborations to propel our mission forward, tapping into our extensive networks and connections.

We are actively engaging in discussions with county government officials to further influence agroecology policies at the county level.



CHALLENGES



In our initial assessment, we didn't fully recognize the significant local demand for leafy vegetables in the Viwandani area, leading to potential supply shortages.

Some of the farmers we worked with prioritized producing for their consumption rather than focusing on generating produce for the market. This impacted the overall supply of leafy vegetables in the region. However, we have mitigated these challenges by trying to address the water challenge so that farmers can expand their gardens and produce more for both subsistence and for the market.

Learned Lessons

Our experience has emphasized the importance of directly engaging with the farming community and demonstrating the benefits and effectiveness of syntropic farming practices. This personal approach is crucial for fostering adoption and creating lasting change.

We have come to understand the critical need to highlight and advocate for both financial and technical support for farmers. This support is essential for enabling farmers to transition to sustainable and economically viable farming practices.

Future Outlook

Looking ahead, we are dedicated to maintaining our focus on conducting regular field visits and fostering strong connections with local farmers and local communities. In the future, we are resolved to elevate farmer incomes, expand access to organic produce, and advance the cause of sustainable agriculture. Considering the supplementary initiatives and advancements outlined, it is evident that the project is on a solid trajectory to meet its goals in the upcoming year.

MORE INFORMATION ABOUT US!



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THANK YOU!